

Case Analysis Template

Current Situation

Step 1. The Facts

WHO is the decision maker?	Senior leadership will be the primary decision makers as they will make the final decision on whether AI should be implemented at ABC Company. Although the CIO is part of the senior leadership team, their role will be to advise other senior (non-technical) leaders on recommendations on how automation should be introduced. Because bias has already been identified as a major concern, the VP of DIBS (Diversity, Inclusion, Belonging, and Societal Impact) should be included in these conversations. Their role will be to evaluate where the AI plan creates any additional risks of unfair hiring outcomes or conflict with organizational equity.
WHAT is the task to be done (decision to make, problem to solve, opportunity to seize)?	This situation acts as a decision tree because each choice creates additional decisions about how automation should be applied across the HR process. ABC company first needs to decide whether AI should be introduced in their HR environment. If implemented, a second decision is to determine which HR tasks should be supported by AI, which should be redesigned through non-AI automation, and which tasks should remain manual. These decisions present an opportunity to improve operational efficiency, strengthen document management practices, improve document quality and consistency, and potentially improve cost savings within HR. However, ABC Company must establish bias reduction strategies so that any automation introduced does not reinforce unfair patterns in hiring, onboarding, or document handling.
WHY has the issue arisen now? What is its significance to the organization?	The CIO recently returned from an automation convention that increased their excitement around the potential of AI and workflow automation. ABC has been experiencing rapid growth and anticipates an increase in hiring and onboarding within the next fiscal year, which furthers increased interest in AI. Leadership has already had discussions about bringing in additional HR personnel (several recruiters and an onboarding specialist) in order to manage the additional workload. However, they were also weighing where process improvement could remove some of the staffing pressures.

	Additionally, ABC is also considering moving its data environment to the cloud which brought attention to its weaknesses in document and content management. As these issues became more visible, it became apparent that ABC needs to address these issues before cloud migration.
WHEN does the decision maker have to decide, resolve, act or dispose of the issue? What is the urgency to the situation?	The CIO and other senior leaders have requested that recommendations be presented by the end of the week. The short deadline is to make the initial strategic decision rather than a full implementation plan, which would take significantly longer. The urgency is to determine if and where AI and automation should move forward in HR before hiring picks up in the next several months.

Step 2. In-Depth Analysis

ABC Company is trying to solve the issue of growing inefficiencies within the HR environment, specifically in hiring and onboarding. Many routine tasks still depend on labor-intensive processes, some of which are creating duplicate work. For example, each time a candidate applied for a position, five different employees must touch the paperwork at some stage throughout recruitment. Similar inefficiencies exist throughout onboarding, including access requests, internal coordination, orientation scheduling, and employee set up. All of these procedures rely on manual workflow. This increases operational effort as well as slows how quickly applicants can move through the HR process. This time could be spent on higher-value activities such as networking and strategic planning. As hiring demands increase, this also creates cost pressures as leadership must decide whether additional personnel are needed to manage future workloads. This is especially important as delays in hiring and onboarding can slow how quickly new employees become productive and limit how effective HR can be in supporting the continual growth.

ABC also faces an information problem in document and content management. Document management concerns are visible resumes, interview notes, hiring paperwork, onboarding forms, and access-related documents that remain stored in a system that has never been meaningfully updated. Content management presents a related issue but applies more towards ABC's collection of video interview recordings, onboarding seminars videos, and digital materials (event flyers, promotion materials, welcome printouts, power points, etc.). Because the records have remained unchanged in the same place over time, outdated and uncontrolled documentation have made it more difficult to manage. This has caused quality to decline and consistency to diminish, resulting in a lack of trust from HR personnel and the leadership team. Because the team spends additional time verifying information and correcting inconsistencies, administrative costs increase on a process that should already be reliable within the system. This also limits leadership's confidence in the information supporting HR decisions.

The current situation is the result of organizational growth and the consideration of cloud migration bringing greater attention to HR inefficiencies and the continued use of poor data management practices. As hiring and onboarding demands increased, manual processes continued to expand around existing workflows. These responsibilities were assigned across staff to keep the work moving; however, it

reinforced undesirable workflow methods. From an IT perspective, records remained in the document environments without any updates or revisions. This resulted in the data stored to be inaccurate, incomplete, inconsistent, and irrelevant. These factors become more significant when automation is introduced because AI systems depend on reliable information and consistent process design in order to support fair outcomes. ABC Company's poor document management increases this risk by limiting how effectively automation can interpret existing records and generate meaningful support for HR decisions.

A well-designed AI system is often intended to reduce bias. AI screening can support more uniform assessments by giving equal weight to applicants, which is one of the reasons many organizations view automation as a way to improve fairness (Upadhyay & Khandelwal, 2018). However, ethical concerns remain when those systems rely on machine learning (ML) models built from historical data and real-world implementation has shown that these systems typically reproduce discrimination when the underlying training data reflects past systemic biases. For example, Amazon's AI recruitment systems were reinforcing gender bias by penalizing resumes that included the word "women" and rewarding more masculine language (Martin, 2022). Similarly, a study conducted by Wilson and Caliskan (2024) showed that several popular resume-screening systems favored white-associated names 85% of the time, while black male candidates experienced a disadvantage 100% of the time. Although ABC Company may have some control over the data entered in its own hiring system, these ML examples were trained by outside SaaS vendors. This means that bias introduced during model development may still carry into ABC's hiring outcomes. This extends beyond resume screening into AI -support interview tools as well. HireVue uses facial movements, tone of voice, eye contact, and perceived enthusiasm to generate employability scores (Martin, 2022). This creates additional ethical concerns because these systems may disadvantage nonnative speakers, neurodivergent individuals, nervous candidates, and those whose behavioral patterns do not reflect what the model deems as "desirable". Unfortunately, identifying these biases can also be difficult because organizations do not always understand how recommendations are produced, while many hiring algorithms continue to operate with limited transparency (Bogen & Rieke, 2018).

Criteria

Use your analysis of the current situation to identify the relevant criteria. The criteria should note what the issue is, then note how its is currently measured, and why this criteria was selected. Note a minimum of three criteria in this section.

Criteria	Meaning/Measurement	Why Selected?
Operational Efficiency	This is one of the highest priority criteria. Improving workflow efficiency is a key reason ABC Company is evaluating process changes. This focuses on reducing duplicate work, shortening time-to-fill and onboarding timelines, improving access management, and increasing personnel capacity to prioritize strategic initiatives.	ABC Company's current HR workflows require repeated manual involvement with increased efforts and create pressure to expand staffing as growth continues. Recruiting and onboarding capacity is already approaching its limit, making process improvements

		necessary before additional workloads create further delays.
DIBS Compliance	DIBS Compliance carries equal importance because process improvements have limited value if they increase likelihood of inequitable outcomes. By supporting DIBS standards, ABC strengthens consistency in candidate treatment and supports broader organizational performance. This is because equitable hiring practices have been shown to improve creativity and long-term organizational effectiveness (Hoffman & Evans, 2021).	Equitable hiring practices are a major consideration in ABC Company's decision process. The CIO has identified bias risk as a key concern when researching automation. Additionally, ABC places strong emphasis on DIBS as a part of its organizational culture. Any proposed solutions must align with these values and support a fair evaluation and treatment.
Data Readiness & Information Reliability	This criterion is just as important as Operational Efficiency and DIBS Compliance. In order for ABC Company to make well-informed decisions, they must ensure that data upholds a high standard for data quality. Records should be accurate and complete so HR personnel and leadership are working from reliable information. Information must also remain consistent and maintain integrity so documents can be stored and accessed in dependable ways. Finally, records must remain relevant so outdated documentation does not continue influencing current decisions (Colorado State University Global, 2026).	With ABC Company's planned cloud migration, it is essential for them to have strong data readiness before records are transferred into a new environment. Improving data quality is also necessary as poor information can weaken decision-making (garbage in, garbage out). In addition, incomplete or inconsistent records increases the likelihood that future processes will reinforce bias rather than support fair and equitable outcomes.
Cost Effectiveness	Cost Effectiveness is an important supporting criterion, although slightly under the other leading priorities. ABC Company must consider the immediate financial commitment required to improve current processes and the ongoing cost attached to maintaining the selected solution over time. Cost should also be evaluated by the return it creates through measurable gains, such as improved efficiency and reduced administrative effort. Indirect benefits should also be weighed which include improved employee moral when HR staff spend less time	Senior leadership wants to understand whether the chosen solution creates financial value beyond its initial costs. While process improvements may address HR inefficiencies, leadership must consider whether those improvements produce measurable savings and justify long-term investment.

	managing avoidable issues and more time focusing on more meaningful work.	
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Analysis of Alternatives

What options are given in the case?

Are there additional options you think need to be considered?

Options		Performance Against Criteria			
		1 Operational Efficiency	2 DIBS Compliance	3 Data Readiness & Information Reliability	4 Cost Effectiveness
	1. Expand HR Staffing & Continue Manual Process	<u>Low</u> Expanding recruitment and onboarding staff can reduce immediate pressure created by the ongoing demand; however, operational inefficiencies still remain. The workflows will continue to rely on manual processes and duplicated work.	<u>High</u> Employees can consciously apply DIBS standards throughout the hiring and onboarding process. Recruiters can adjust decisions when they recognize fairness concerns or unique candidate context. Nevertheless, unconscious bias remains a limitation because human judgement still influences how candidates are evaluated and selected. Although, this type of	<u>Moderate-Low</u> Manual processes allow HR to identify errors and correct records when issues are noticed, but long-term data quality still depends heavily on individual consistency. Training can improve how consistently documentation is maintained, it still heavily depends on execution. Different documentation practices may continue, especially when document and content quality issues were already present.	<u>Low</u> Expanding HR has some major upfront investments as well as long-term costs. Even in today's market, hiring costs can exceed 3 times the salary of the position you are trying to fill (Navarra, 2022). Once hired, ABC will be responsible for paying their salary and benefits. This creates scalability concerns as future hiring demands may require additional staffing. Manual work also limits potential financial gains when

			bias can be corrected through continuous DIBS trainings.		staff continue spending time on routine administrative work rather than higher-value planning and strategic activities.
	2. Implement AI-Driven HR Process with Limited Oversight	High This offers the strongest operational efficiency out of all options. AI can process large volumes of application, automatically assign access controls, schedule activities (schedule interviews, orientation, etc.), and handle the candidate disposition process (Murugesan et al., 2023). This option is also highly scalable as process speed does not depend on staff capacity. Machine learning can be utilized to analyze data and support talent-decisions allowing candidates to move through the process much quicker (Alghamdi & Al-Baity, 2022).	Low DIBS compliance is difficult within this type of environment, especially in its current documentation management state. AI decisions drawn from ABC's current environment will increase the likelihood of biased outcomes on how applicants are evaluated. Additionally, ML models developed by outside SaaS vendors may introduce bias that ABC cannot fully control. This reflects the earlier concerns discussed in the in-depth analysis.	High Once established, this option can significantly improve the maintenance of data readiness and information reliability. AI systems apply the same structure across HR processes with minimal variation, creating greater consistency throughout the workflow. With proper guidance during implementation, data can be maintained more effectively across recruiting and onboarding. This further supports data quality because automated records are more likely to remain accurate, complete, consistent, and relevant.	Moderate The automated workflows reduce the amount of manual administrative work across recruiting and onboarding allowing work staff to spend more of their time on strategic initiatives. However, enterprise AI platforms require substantial recurring SaaS costs, not including implementation and integration expenses. Workday, one of the most popular application tracking systems (ATS) globally, charges roughly \$100k per year for their product, while others have pay per user program (Alex, 2026).

	3. Implement AI-Driven HR Process with Human-in-the-Loop (HITL)	<u>Moderate-High</u> HITL maintains strong operational efficiency similar to limited oversight. However, routing decisions through human review introduces additional workflow steps which can slow the overall process.	<u>Moderate</u> This improved compliance by combining AI efficiency with human judgement which allows personnel to review outcomes before decisions are finalized. Blending automation with human oversight creates a more responsible approach, since human review adds context when AI does not fully understand situational context (McCormack & Bendeckache, 2024). However, it is important for ABC to note that AI systems are still trained by outside SaaS vendors, introducing the risk mentioned before. Additionally, limited transparency creates an environment where it is difficult to identify when biased patterns are presenting themselves (Bogen & Rieke, 2018).	<u>High</u> This mirrors the AI-driven process with limited oversight, as automated workflows still maintain consistent structure and standardized data handling.	<u>Moderate-Low</u> HITL carries the same recurring SaaS and implementation costs as the AI-driven process with limited oversight while also required continued human involvement throughout the workflow. Although automation still reduces administrative efforts, the added step increases labor demands and limits the full financial benefits for full automation.
	4. Automate & Optimize Non-AI Workflow	<u>Moderate-High</u> Non-AI automated workflows improve	<u>High</u> DIBS compliance remains strong since	<u>Moderate-High</u> Readiness and reliability of ABC Company's data	<u>High</u> ABC Company can improve efficiency by

		operational efficiency by reducing repetitive manual tasks. Murugesan et al. (2023) note that automating routine HR activities allows staff to spend less time on administrative handling and more time on higher-value responsibilities. This can be accomplished by structured routing where certain task completions trigger data to be forward to the next steps in the process (e.g. when a candidate accepts their offer, their information will be automatically transferred from the ATS into the HRIS. This will then trigger onboarding activities such as automated scheduling, access control approvals, etc.). When a position has been filled, or a candidate is dispositioned for other reasons, automated notifications can be prompted sending out a rejection email. ABC	hiring decisions continue to rely on human judgement rather than external ML models. Automated workflows can improve fairness by applying the same process across all applicant and new employees, with the added benefit of understanding context. However, this depends on ABC Company's ability to improve its current document management environment. Poor data quality can still affect how information is reviewed through recruiting and onboarding.	can be automated so information is captured in a consistent format. They can also control input fields within their ATS and HRIS systems, which would help reference data remain aligned across all HR records. Since human entry still remains part of several processes, long-term consistency can be more difficult to maintain than a fully automated environment. Additional training can reduce this variation by reinforcing documentation standards.	using its existing HR infrastructure as ATS and HRIS systems can create automated workflows. In this scenario, there will be no need to invest in new AI platforms or expanding long-term staff. Most initial costs are tied to internal work efforts needed to improve automation, optimization, strengthen documentation, and additional training. If current staff capacity is limited, a short-term contractor could support implementation without creating permanent labor costs.
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		Companies recruitment and onboarding process can also be optimized by streamlining how tasks move within and between departments, which will reduce delays caused by unnecessary hand-offs. For instance, no more 5 people touchpoints for candidate information. With that being said, efficiency remains below AI-Driven alternatives since decision-making still depends on human review and core hiring activities.			
	5. Adopt a Hybrid Model with Deliberate Process Allocation	<u>Moderate-High</u> Tasks will be assigned to the best method best suited for each of the HR processes. AI can support high-volume activities that do not require human judgement (interview scheduling, candidate communication, etc). This will allow those processes to move quicker without slowing more sensitive decision	<u>High</u> ABC Company must carefully evaluate which tasks should be AI, automated, or manually reviewed. Earlier examples show that AI tools can reflect vendor-trained bias, so activities that directly influence candidate selection should require human judgement. Although AI tools may have these limitations, restricting	<u>Moderate-High</u> This builds on the same structured data advantages found in non-AI workflow automation where controlled fields and standardized formats improve consistency. Selective AI use can strengthen this further by maintaining uniformity in repetitive administrative activities. However, manual	<u>Moderate</u> This option would be towards the lower end of moderate, though not quite moderate-low. Although it avoids the expense of a fully AI-driven platform, ABC Company will still need to acquire multiple AI tools designed for the specific tasks they would want accomplished. These costs can get expensive

		making. Workflow automation also reduces repetitive steps across recruiting and onboarding (similar to above). Manual involvement remains in areas requiring greater human intuition which will prevent the process from reaching the speeds of full AI automation. Though, the introduction of AI to certain can create stronger efficiencies than non-AI workflow automation and optimization.	their use in administrative activities reduces the likelihood that those biases directly affect hiring outcomes. In order to relieve some of the price burden, routine workflows in which the ATS/HRIS systems can easily accomplish will be automated. Lastly, sensitive and high bias potential workflows will be handled manually to align with DIBS expectations.	involvement still remains in several processes, so long-term consistency depends on continued training and documentation standards.	quickly when software is purchased separately or layered across systems. At the same time, efficiency increases will allow staff to spend less time on repetitive work and more time supporting strategic initiatives.
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Decision

Which option do you think is best? Why?

Before selecting any option, ABC Company must first address its document management environment and establish strong data governance practices. This is especially important as ABC considers cloud migration, since poor-quality records transferred into a new environment will continue to create the same limitation. Additionally, every selection requires ABC Company to have reliable resumes, onboarding forms, access-related documents, and other HR materials being maintained in a consistent way. In its current state, weak document controls create risk regardless of manual, automated, or AI-driven processes. Operational improvements may still produce unreliable outcomes which lead ABC to poor decision-making. Historical files should be archived from other HR files. Irrelevant records should not remain mixed within active decision-making environments where they may influence current hiring decisions. Older resumes, interview records, onboarding documents, and prior content can still provide insights, so they should not be deleted. This can be presented through long-term trend analysis or workforce planning. Recruiters could use these records to source potential candidates who have been engaged with ABC Company throughout their history. Establishing data readiness & information reliability first ensures that whichever option leadership selects will be built on more reliable information.

The initial consideration to expand HR staffing and continue the manual process scored the weakest of all considerations. Although additional personnel may increase workload capacities, it does not solve the underlying problem ABC Company is trying to solve. The organization will continue to carry out inefficiencies while adding long-term salary and benefit obligations as they continue to grow. At the same time, an AI-driven process with limited oversight creates the strongest efficiencies; however, its low DIBS compliance introduces significant ethical concerns. Many of these can be addressed by HITL. Unfortunately, AI systems still rely on external vendor-trained models and limited transparency makes biased outcomes difficult for HR staff to identify even when human review is present (Bogen & Rieke, 2018).

Adopting a hybrid model remains a strong alternative as it balances efficiency, DIBS, and documentation management. However, introducing AI into HR tasks might still be premature for ABC Company at its current stage. The company's irrelevant records, document quality, and data consistency suggest that workflow improvements should first be strengthened before AI is added to HR operations. Additionally, AI is a new, rapidly expanding market where long-term biases in their systems are still being identified. It would be reasonable for ABC to monitor adoption as the industry further matures before committing to additional software investment. Lastly, leadership prioritized financial outcomes. This makes automating and optimizing non-AI workflows the clear winner. It offers strong immediate RIO by improving efficiency without adding AI platform costs while still scoring high on operational efficiency, DIBS compliance, and data readiness & information reliability.

How does this proposed solution address the business problem identified in your analysis of the current situation?

This recommendation improves the current manual workflow issues slowing recruiting and onboarding. Automation with ABC Company's existing ATS and HRIS systems would improve how candidates' information is transferred and streamline tasks (interview scheduling, access requirements, orientation coordination, employee setup, etc.). Optimization could further improve efficiency by reducing repeated paperwork. DIBS alignment will be strong as it avoids many of the ethical concerns discussed with AI-supported decision making. Since this approach builds on systems ABC already uses, it strengthens how active records are maintained without creating added costs associated with AI. This gives the organization an immediate process improvement while creating a strong foundation for future decisions if AI becomes more practical later.

What are the ethical aspects to consider in regard to this decision?

Even without AI, ethical considerations still remain part of the decision. A good aspect for bias reduction is that automation improves consistency; however, fairness still depends on human judgement. Recruiters will be responsible for resume review, interview interpretation, document quality (though with the aid of automation and controlled fields), and deciding if a candidate should be moved forward or dispositioned. Additionally, if documentation continues to be inconsistent or incomplete, those same issues can affect hiring decisions and employee experience. Luckily, if ABC Company dedicates resources to further trainings, these issues can be minimized. ABC leadership must also be cognizant that process improvements do not create situations in which efficiency becomes more important than fairness and other DIBS initiatives.

Implementation

How will you go about implementing your decision (who will do what, when, and how)?

Short Term (4-8 wks)	Medium Term (3-6 mths)	Long Term (4-12 mths / Ongoing)	Long Term (1+ yrs)
IT, data owners, and stewards should focus on cleaning up ABC's document management environment. This should include establishing a common organizational vocabulary, improving data quality, and achieving irrelevant records. During this stage, ABC should also establish clearer documentation standards, so records are entered and maintained in a uniform way. Completing this first allows later automation efforts to build from more reliable information.	This time should centered around optimizing HR workflows and introducing automation within ABC Company's existing software. HR leadership should work with IT and system administrators to identify where repetitive tasks can be automatically triggered. These leaders should partner with ATS and HRIS providers to understand automation capabilities. Improving how offers transfer to onboarding, interviewing scheduling, access request, orientation, and employee set up are common workflows that typical ATS/HRIS systems can automate. Additionally, departments involved in onboarding should review delays where unnecessary handoffs can be removed. The goal is to make the process move more effectively while still keeping DIBS in mind.	Continuous training will be an important aspect of this implementation plan. HR leadership should establish ongoing data governance training to reinforce documentation standards and prevent poor record management from reemerging. Technical training should provide staff an understanding on how to properly use automated workflows and follow updated SoP's. Additionally, DIBS training remains important since hiring decisions relies on human judgement and potential unconscious bias. Long-term success will depend on making these practices part of normal HR operations rather than treating them as a one-time implementation effort.	ABC leadership should periodically re-evaluate whether AI becomes a more practical option for future adoption. This review should consider if situations have improved in the realm operational efficiency, bias reduction, and cost. This allows ABC Company to remain aware of future opportunities without committing to technology prematurely

What are the major risks associated with your decision?

A large risk in this decision is that poor data quality and weak documentation practices could persist even after workflow improvements are introduced. If records remain inaccurate, incomplete, inconsistent, and irrelevant, automation will still move flawed information through the

process. Another risk is that bias may still appear in automation even when core DIBS sensitive decisions remain manual. Biases have a habit of showing up in unexpected places, and workflows can still create unintended disadvantages if process rules are not periodically revalidated. The most important risk is weak user adoption. One of the most common challenges a company can face in a process, or technology, change is getting employees to consistently follow the new approach (Stair & Reynolds, 2018). If staff do not adopt the new workflows, DIBS initiatives, or data governance, old habits will cause ABC Company to revert back to where they started.

What steps will you take to avoid or mitigate those risks?

Many of these risks can be reduced by following the same implementation steps already outlined in this recommendation. Strong data governance should remain in place, so documentation standards continue and active records are reviewed for quality over time. Workflow changes should also be reviewed periodically so automation can be adjusted if unintended issues begin to appear. Training is one of the most important long-term controls since user adoption is often one of the hardest parts of implementing new processes or technology. According to Stair and Reynolds (2018), process change depends heavily on employees understanding why the change is being made and how to properly work within it. Continued technical training, documentation standards, and DIBS reinforcement will help reduce the chances of old habits returning or hidden bias affecting outcomes.

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AI Use Statement

ChatGPT (OpenAI) was used to support brainstorming, sentence refinement, paragraph structure, and alignment of prior coursework with current assignment requirements. Prompts focused on strengthening transitions between sections, improving clarity of written explanations, evaluating where previous academic work could support new rubric requirements, and refining source integration. All analysis, interpretation, conclusions, and final written decisions remain the author's own work.